

American experience

A breakthrough came in 1943, when Serge Koussevitzky, the Russian-born director of the Boston Symphony Orchestra, commissioned Bartók to create a major orchestral work for a fee of \$1,000. The result was the Concerto for Orchestra, a magnificent orchestral showpiece that ranges in tone from dark ferocity and despair to outright satire, mocking the use of a theme from Lehár's *The Merry Widow* in Shostakovich's Seventh Symphony.

The work was received with acclaim. More commissions followed, including a violin sonata written for Yehudi Menuhin, and the Viola Concerto. However, this last work was left incomplete—Bartók's illness had finally caught up with him. The composer died on September 26, 1945, aged 64. On his deathbed, he told his doctor: "What I most regret is having to leave with a full trunk."